

Topic 6: Diverse Places

This topic examines how and why places vary, how they change over time, and how different people experience and perceive the same place differently. You must study two contrasting places in depth: one local place investigated through fieldwork, and one contrasting place (different region, different socioeconomic profile).

6.1 What is a Place?

Place: A location with meaning. Places are given character by the people who live there, the activities that occur, and the physical environment. Place is a fundamental concept in geography that goes beyond simple location to include identity, lived experience, emotional attachment, and social significance. A space becomes a place when people imbue it with meaning.

Sense of place: The subjective emotional attachment people have to a place, shaped by personal experiences, memories, cultural connections, and length of residence. This varies between individuals and groups — two residents of the same street may have very different senses of place.

Perception of place: How people view and interpret a place, shaped by direct experience, media representations, education, cultural background, and social identity. Perception may differ significantly from measurable reality — a neighbourhood perceived as dangerous may actually have average crime rates.

Insider and Outsider Perspectives

Insider Perspective	Outsider Perspective
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Lived experience of people who belong to the place	Views of visitors, tourists, media, government agencies, developers
Deep, nuanced knowledge shaped by daily routines, relationships, and memories	May be superficial, relying on stereotypes, statistics, or limited visits
Emotional connection: pride, nostalgia, frustration, belonging	More detached, analytical, may focus on measurable characteristics
May take local features for granted; can be blind to gradual changes	Can notice contrasts, differences, and features that insiders overlook
Multiple insider perspectives exist (young/old, rich/poor, long-term/newcomer)	Outsider views are often shaped by dominant media narratives

Place Representations

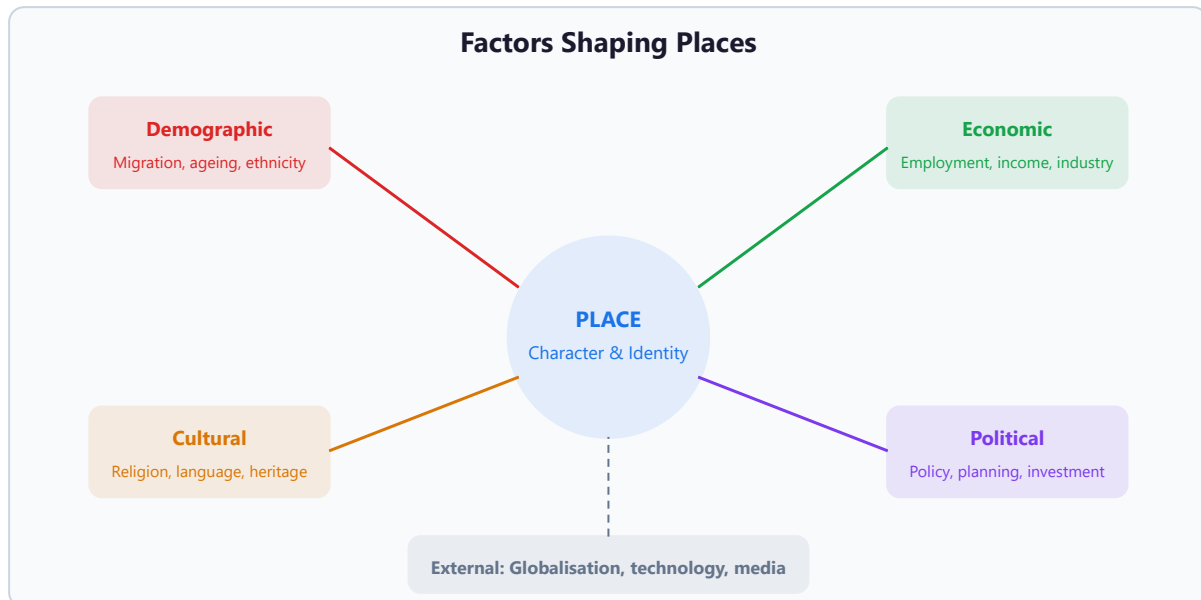
How places are portrayed by different agents shapes how they are perceived, valued, and invested in:

- **Formal/quantitative representations** — census data, government statistics (ONS), Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD), maps, planning documents, council reports, tourism brochures. These appear objective but involve choices about what to measure, categorise, and highlight. IMD data can stigmatise areas by labelling them "most deprived."
- **Informal/qualitative representations** — films, TV, novels, music, social media, photography, street art, oral histories. These shape popular perception powerfully: "Peaky Blinders" transformed Birmingham's image; "Broadchurch" boosted tourism to West Bay, Dorset; negative media coverage of crime can stigmatise neighbourhoods, deterring investment and reinforcing deprivation.
- **Critical questions about representations:** Who created it? Why? For whom? What is emphasised/omitted? Whose perspective does it reflect? What power relationships does it reinforce?

Exam Tip: Edexcel requires you to study two contrasting places. Be prepared to compare them using specific quantitative data (census, IMD, house prices, employment) and qualitative evidence (interviews, photographs, fieldwork observations). Always use your own fieldwork findings as evidence — this demonstrates the practical application of geographical skills.

6.2 How and Why Places Change

Factors Driving Change



Demographic Change

- **International migration** — transforms the ethnic, cultural, and linguistic character of places. Post-war Commonwealth migration transformed areas of London (Brixton: Caribbean community), Birmingham (Sparkbrook: South Asian community), and Leicester (which the 2021 Census showed to be one of the UK's first "majority minority" cities, with only ~33% White British and ~59% from ethnic minority groups). More recent migration from EU accession states (2004): Eastern European communities in Boston, Lincolnshire (one of the highest shares of Eastern European-born residents in England by 2011).
- **Internal migration** — rural-urban migration (young people leaving villages for cities), suburbanisation (families moving to suburbs for space), counter-urbanisation (professionals moving to rural areas, especially post-COVID), gentrification (wealthier people moving into deprived inner-city areas).
- **Natural change** — ageing populations in rural/coastal areas (young people leave, retirees move in); youthful populations in inner-city areas with large immigrant communities (higher birth rates).

Economic Change

- **Deindustrialisation** — decline of manufacturing since 1970s. UK manufacturing employment fell from 7.9 million (1971) to 2.7 million (2020). Former industrial areas (Sheffield, Glasgow, Teesside, Welsh

Valleys) experienced unemployment, depopulation, deprivation, and loss of identity. The "levelling up" agenda (2019–24) aimed to address this.

- **Tertiarisation** — shift to service sector economy. 83% of UK employment is now in services. Growth concentrated in London and the South East, widening the North-South divide.
- **Globalisation** — some places benefit from global investment (Sunderland: Nissan factory employing ~6,000, with peak output of ~500,000 cars/yr in 2016; Cambridge: biotech/tech cluster); others lose out as industries relocate overseas (Redcar steelworks closed 2015: 2,200 jobs lost when SSI, a Thai company, pulled out).
- **Retail change** — rise of online shopping (UK online retail: 27% of total sales, 2023) devastating high streets. Average town centre vacancy rate: ~14%. Conversely, some town centres reinventing themselves through "experience economy" (restaurants, entertainment, markets).

Processes of Urban Change

Gentrification: The process by which wealthier people move into a previously lower-income area, renovating properties, changing the commercial character (independent coffee shops, boutiques replacing takeaways and betting shops), and ultimately raising property values and rents. This can displace existing residents who can no longer afford to live there. The term was coined by sociologist Ruth Glass in 1964, describing changes in Islington, London.

Studentification: The influx of students into specific neighbourhoods near universities, converting family housing into Houses of Multiple Occupation (HMOs). Impacts: seasonal population fluctuations, changed retail character (takeaways, bars), noise/antisocial behaviour complaints, rising rents pricing out families, but also economic activity and cultural vibrancy. Headingley (Leeds) and Fallowfield (Manchester) are examples.

Urban regeneration: Planned investment to revitalise declining areas, improving infrastructure, housing, employment, and public spaces. Can be property-led (Canary Wharf), culture-led (Tate Modern, Baltic Gateshead), community-led (community land trusts), or transport-led (Crossrail/Elizabeth Line).

6.3 Population Characteristics and Diversity

Measuring Diversity

Place profiles use quantitative data to describe population characteristics:

- **Population size and density** — from census data; identifies urban/rural character
- **Age structure** — young/ageing populations; dependency ratios; median age
- **Ethnicity and nationality** — ethnic composition, country of birth, languages spoken. London: 270+ nationalities, 300+ languages. About 41% of Londoners were born outside the UK (2021 Census).
- **Employment structure** — primary/secondary/tertiary/quaternary sectors; unemployment rate; economic activity rate
- **Income and deprivation** — average household income; IMD scores and rankings. England's most deprived LSOA (2019 and 2025): Jaywick, Essex. The least deprived areas are mainly in the South East (e.g. Hart, Hampshire, the least deprived local authority in 2019).
- **Housing** — tenure (owner-occupied, private rented, social housing); house prices; housing type (detached, semi, terraced, flats)
- **Health** — life expectancy; obesity rates; access to healthcare. Life expectancy varies by around 10 years, and healthy life expectancy by nearly 20 years, between England's most and least deprived areas.
- **Education** — GCSE/A-Level attainment; university participation rates; adult qualifications
- **Crime** — crime rates per 1,000 population; types of crime; perception of safety

The UK's Diverse Population

The UK's population has become increasingly diverse through successive waves of migration:

Period	Migration Wave	Impact on Places
1948–1970s	Commonwealth migration (Caribbean, South Asian, East African)	Settled in industrial cities: London (Brixton, Southall, Tower Hamlets), Birmingham (Sparkbrook, Handsworth), Bradford, Leicester. Filled post-war labour shortages in transport, NHS, manufacturing.
1970s–1990s	Family reunification; refugees (Vietnamese, Somali, Kurdish)	Ethnic communities consolidated; cultural institutions established (mosques, temples, community centres). Some areas became ethnically concentrated.

2004–2016	EU accession state migration (Poland, Lithuania, Latvia, Romania, Bulgaria)	Dispersed more widely than previous waves: smaller towns, rural areas (agricultural work). Boston, Lincolnshire: one of the highest Eastern European-born populations in England by 2011. New shops, churches, cultural centres.
2016–present	Post-Brexit shift: reduced EU migration, increased non-EU migration (India, Nigeria, Philippines, Hong Kong)	Net migration peaked at around 900,000 (year to mid-2023, ONS revised estimate) despite Brexit, before falling to about 200,000 by mid-2025. International student numbers grew. Health and social care workers recruited from South Asia and Philippines. Hong Kong BN(O) scheme: over 150,000 visas granted.

Benefits and Challenges of Diversity

Benefits	Challenges
Cultural richness: food, music, festivals, languages, arts (Notting Hill Carnival: 2 million visitors; Diwali celebrations in Leicester: largest outside India)	Segregation: some areas have high ethnic concentration, with limited interaction between communities (Bradford: 70%+ of school children in some wards are of Pakistani heritage)
Economic contribution: migrants fill labour shortages, start businesses, pay taxes (UCL study: European migrants contributed £20 billion net to UK 2001–2011)	Integration challenges: language barriers, cultural differences, discrimination, Islamophobia/racism
Innovation and entrepreneurship (40% of Fortune 500 companies founded by immigrants or their children)	Pressure on services: housing, schools, healthcare in areas of high concentration
Demographic balance: younger migrants offset ageing native population	Social tension: far-right politics, hate crimes (increased 26% after Brexit referendum), community divisions
Global connections: diaspora communities facilitate trade, investment, and cultural exchange	Media stigmatisation of diverse areas, reinforcing negative perceptions

Case Study: Tower Hamlets, London — A Diverse and Changing Place

Tower Hamlets (East London, population ~320,000) is one of the UK's most diverse and rapidly changing boroughs. **Demographics:** 35% Bangladeshi heritage (largest Bangladeshi community in Europe, concentrated around Brick Lane/Banglatown), ~23% White British (2021), significant Somali, Chinese, and Eastern European communities. 41% of residents born outside UK. **Economic extremes:** Tower Hamlets contains both Canary Wharf (one of the world's major financial centres: 120,000 workers, average salary £100,000+) and some of England's most deprived wards (Spitalfields: child poverty rate 56%). Average house price: £450,000, but 42% of housing is social rent. **Change over time:** historically a port area and home to successive immigrant communities (Huguenots 17th C, Irish 19th C, Jewish early 20th C, Bangladeshi 1970s+). Since 2000: massive regeneration driven by Canary Wharf expansion, 2012 Olympics (nearby), and private development. Population grew ~58% (2001–2021), to ~310,000. **Tensions:** gentrification displacing Bangladeshi community (Brick Lane curry houses declining from 50+ to ~20); social housing waiting lists (20,000 households); cultural tensions between communities; widening inequality between financial workers and long-term residents. **Significance:** Tower Hamlets encapsulates the complexities of diversity, inequality, and rapid change in 21st-century urban Britain.

Case Study: Jaywick, Essex — England's Most Deprived Place

Jaywick Sands, a small coastal settlement near Clacton-on-Sea (population ~5,000), has been ranked as the most deprived neighbourhood in England in every IMD survey since 2010. **Characteristics:** originally built as a holiday camp in the 1930s (chalets designed for summer use, not permanent habitation), but became permanent housing. 62% of residents are economically inactive; median household income: £14,000 (less than half national average); 50% of adults have no qualifications; life expectancy 8 years below national average. Many properties lack proper foundations, insulation, or drainage. Flood risk: the entire settlement is below sea level, protected only by a sea wall. **Why so deprived?** Peripheral coastal location (limited employment), poor transport connections (no railway), low land values attracted low-income residents, absentee landlords, poor-quality housing stock, limited local services, ageing population. **Regeneration attempts:** Tendring District Council invested £5 million in a new community centre, improved roads, and a pilot scheme to renovate 10 homes. The government's "Jaywick Sands Place Plan" proposes new housing and infrastructure. However, progress is slow due to limited funding, complex land ownership, flood risk, and the scale of deprivation. Jaywick illustrates how place decline can become self-reinforcing: deprivation deters investment, which deepens deprivation.

Case Study: Rural Change — The Cotswolds

The Cotswolds (Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty, renamed a National Landscape in 2023, 2,038 km², population ~140,000) represents a contrasting type of place change: rural gentrification and counter-urbanisation. **Characteristics:** affluent, picturesque villages with honey-coloured limestone buildings, rolling countryside, heritage tourism (6 million visitors/yr). Average house price: £425,000 (2023), well above national average (£290,000). **Change drivers:** counter-urbanisation (wealthy Londoners buying second homes and retirement properties, accelerated by COVID remote working); tourism growth; agricultural decline (farm employment fell 60% since 1950). **Impacts:** rising house prices making villages unaffordable for young locals (affordable housing provision: only 5% of new builds); loss of services (village shops, pubs, post offices closing as permanent population falls); "dormitory villages" where commuters live but contribute little to community; seasonal economy dependent on tourism; conflict between conservation (AONB restrictions limit development) and housing need. **Positive aspects:** well-maintained landscape, low crime, strong community spirit (in some villages), high environmental quality. The Cotswolds illustrates how rural places can be simultaneously "successful" (affluent, attractive) and struggling (hollowed-out communities, unaffordable for locals, dependent on tourism).

6.4 Managing Change and Conflict in Diverse Places

Regeneration Strategies

- **Top-down (government/developer-led)** — large-scale investment, often property-led. Can attract significant capital and transform places rapidly but may not benefit existing residents. Risk of gentrification and displacement. Examples: London Docklands (1980s), Olympic Park/Stratford (2012), Salford Quays/MediaCityUK.
- **Bottom-up (community-led)** — local empowerment through neighbourhood plans, community land trusts (CLTs), social enterprises, community development trusts. More inclusive and responsive to local needs but often lack resources and political power. Examples: Granby Four Streets CLT (Liverpool) won Turner Prize 2015 for community-led renovation of derelict Victorian terraces; Coin Street Community Builders (South Bank, London).
- **Culture-led** — using arts, heritage, and creative industries to transform places. Hull UK City of Culture 2017: £300 million economic impact, 5.3 million visits, 800 events. Margate: Turner Contemporary

gallery (opened 2011) attracted 4 million visitors in 10 years, catalysing regeneration of a declining seaside town.

Conflict and Contestation

Place change inevitably creates tensions between different groups:

- **Gentrification vs affordability** — improved physical environment and services vs displacement of low-income residents. Brixton, London: once predominantly Caribbean community, now rapidly gentrifying (Brixton Village market transformed from Afro-Caribbean traders to artisan food stalls; average house prices rose from £165,000 (2005) to £530,000 (2023)).
- **Development vs conservation** — economic growth vs heritage preservation and environmental protection. Conflicts over building on green belt, demolishing historic buildings, and intensifying land use.
- **Local vs national/global interests** — community priorities may differ from government or corporate agendas. HS2 route sparked fierce local opposition despite claimed national economic benefits.
- **Immigration and integration** — tensions between established and newer communities over housing, services, and cultural identity. Must be handled sensitively: both celebrating diversity and addressing legitimate concerns about pace of change.

Exam Tip: Edexcel Diverse Places questions require you to use evidence from your TWO studied places. Always be prepared to: (1) describe and explain the characteristics of each place using specific data (IMD rank, census figures, house prices, employment data), (2) explain how and why each place has changed over time, (3) compare how different groups experience each place, (4) evaluate the effectiveness of strategies to manage change. Your fieldwork evidence should feature prominently.

Exam Tip: When analysing place representations in the exam (photographs, data, text extracts), always consider: Who created this? For what purpose? What does it emphasise? What does it omit? How might different groups interpret it? Is it an insider or outsider perspective? Every representation is partial and selective. Demonstrating this critical awareness earns high marks.

Exam Tip: For 12-mark "evaluate" questions, you need a clear thesis with supporting evidence AND counter-evidence. For example: "Evaluate the success of regeneration in [your studied place]." Structure: what was done (describe the strategy), evidence of success (improved employment, house

prices, services), evidence of limitations (who was excluded, what problems remain, unintended consequences like gentrification), and a balanced conclusion with a judgement. Use specific data from your place studies.

6.5 Canary Wharf — Regeneration Case Study in Depth

Case Study: Canary Wharf — Property-Led Regeneration in London Docklands

Canary Wharf, on the Isle of Dogs in Tower Hamlets, is the UK's most dramatic example of property-led urban regeneration. **Before regeneration:** the London Docklands were the busiest port in the world until the 1960s. Containerisation made the deep-water docks redundant; the West India Docks closed in 1980, leaving 8 square miles of derelict waterfront. Unemployment in Tower Hamlets reached 24% (1981). The area had 39,000 residents, predominantly working-class, white British dock workers and their families. Infrastructure was poor; public transport was minimal. **The London Docklands Development Corporation (LDDC):** established by the Thatcher government in 1981 as a non-elected Urban Development Corporation. The LDDC bypassed the local council (which it saw as obstructive) and had powers to acquire land compulsorily, grant planning permission, and channel central government money. This top-down, government-developer partnership model was controversial from the outset. **Canary Wharf development:** Canadian developer Olympia & York began construction of Canary Wharf in 1987, supported by £2 billion in public infrastructure (Docklands Light Railway, Jubilee Line extension £3.5 billion). One Canada Square (1991) became the UK's tallest building (at the time). Development stalled after Olympia & York's bankruptcy (1992) but was revived; today Canary Wharf covers 97 acres with 120,000 workers. **Economic regeneration (positive outcomes):** 120,000 high-skilled workers employed (banks: HSBC, Barclays, JP Morgan; law firms; media). Average salary in Canary Wharf: £100,000+. 37 million square feet of commercial space. £10 billion in business rates revenue generated. Crossrail/Elizabeth Line station (2022) further improves connectivity. **Social regeneration (contested):** population of the Isle of Dogs grew from 39,000 to 110,000 by 2021. However, most new residents are young professionals and wealthy incomers; the original dockworking community largely left, unable to afford new housing or find employment in financial services. Average house price in Isle of Dogs: £690,000 (2023), compared to £60,000 before regeneration (inflation-adjusted). Social housing proportion fell from 80% to 42%. Child poverty in surrounding Poplar wards: 56%. **Community criticism:** the regeneration was designed for and by an external elite; the LDDC's 17-year operation (1981–1998) spent £9 billion but built only 1,900 affordable homes out of 25,000 total. Local residents describe feeling "like strangers

in our own area." Community groups (Docklands Forum) consistently opposed the top-down model.

Geographical significance: Canary Wharf demonstrates that property-led regeneration can spectacularly transform the physical and economic landscape while failing to address deprivation among existing communities. The "trickle-down" theory (that wealth created at Canary Wharf would benefit surrounding communities) has not been borne out by data. Tower Hamlets remains one of the most deprived London boroughs (with the highest child poverty rate in the UK) despite containing one of the world's major financial centres — a powerful illustration of how globalisation and regeneration can deepen inequality.

6.6 Bradford — Ethnic Diversity and Integration

Case Study: Bradford — Ethnic Diversity, Segregation, and Social Cohesion

Bradford (population 550,000) in West Yorkshire is one of the UK's most ethnically diverse cities and provides a rich case study of the complexities of multicultural Britain. **Historical context:** Bradford was a centre of the wool and textile industry in the 19th and early 20th centuries. Post-war labour shortages drew Commonwealth migrants, predominantly from Pakistan (Mirpur district) and India, to work in Bradford's mills. By the 1970s, a substantial South Asian community was established; by 2021, Bradford had one of the highest proportions of Pakistani-heritage residents of any UK city (2021 Census: ~26% Pakistani heritage, ~3% Indian, ~2% Bangladeshi; ~39% from ethnic minority groups). The Muslim population (predominantly Pakistani) numbers ~165,000 (~30% of total). **Economic context:** Bradford's textile industry collapsed through the 1970s–1990s as manufacturing moved to Asia. Unemployment hit 20%+ in some wards. The Pakistani community, recruited into low-skilled mill jobs, was disproportionately affected by deindustrialisation and concentrated in deprived inner-city wards (Manningham, Toller, Bradford Moor). Bradford is ranked 8th most deprived local authority in England (IMD 2019). **Spatial segregation:** Bradford is frequently cited as an example of ethnic residential segregation. Research by Ted Cantle (2001 Cantle Report, following Bradford riots 2001) described "parallel lives" — communities living side-by-side with minimal interaction. Some inner Bradford wards are 70%+ South Asian; outer suburbs are predominantly White British. School segregation is pronounced: some city-centre primary schools are 90%+ Muslim pupils. **The 2001 Bradford riots:** violent confrontations between young Pakistani men, far-right groups (BNP, National Front), and police. 326 police injured; £10 million property damage; ~300 arrested; long custodial sentences (often four years or more) were later criticised as disproportionate. Triggered by far-right provocations and long-standing tensions about economic marginalisation, institutional racism, and a

sense of being "abandoned" by the state. The riots preceded the Cantle Report and Ouseley Report, both of which highlighted failures of multiculturalism in Bradford. **Positive aspects of diversity:** Mela festivals (South Asian music, food, cultural celebration) attract 100,000+ visitors. Bradford's "Curry Capital of Britain" title and restaurant scene. Community networks provide social support. Bradford has produced prominent national figures (MP Naz Shah, musician Zayn Malik). **Recent developments:** Bradford City of Culture 2025 — a major public investment in arts and culture to reposition Bradford's image and drive economic regeneration (£380 million economic benefit projected). This culture-led approach is intended to bridge communities and attract investment to a city with significant economic challenges. **Geographical lessons:** Bradford illustrates that ethnic diversity is not inherently a problem but that the combination of economic deprivation, residential segregation, poor community relations, and political marginalisation can create social tensions. Cohesion requires investment in mixed-community spaces, shared economic opportunity, and political representation.

6.7 Contrasting Places: Inner London vs Whitby

Case Study: Contrasting Places — Inner-City London vs Whitby, North Yorkshire

Edexcel requires comparison of contrasting places. This example contrasts an inner-city London area (using Brixton, Lambeth as the urban study) with Whitby, a small coastal town in North Yorkshire.

Characteristic	Brixton, Lambeth (Inner London)	Whitby, North Yorkshire
Population	~320,000 in borough; Brixton ward ~18,000	~13,000 in town; declining slowly
Population density	10,400 per km ² (very high)	~300 per km ² (low)
Ethnic composition (2021)	~40% White British; ~24% Black African/Caribbean; ~7% Asian; ~30% other White, Mixed and other (Lambeth)	97% White British
Average house price (2023)	£530,000	£220,000

IMD deprivation rank	Significant deprivation in Brixton wards (top 20% most deprived nationally)	Some deprivation (coastal towns typically deprived) but less acute
Unemployment rate	~6-7% (above London average)	~5% but seasonal tourism dependence creates income volatility
Economic base	Diverse: service sector, retail, creative industries, public sector, gig economy. Gentrification bringing higher-income residents.	Tourism (2 million visitors/yr), fishing, retail, some agriculture. Limited employment diversity.
Age structure	Young: median age ~30, high birth rate, large 20-35 cohort (young professionals, families)	Ageing: median age ~47; young people leave for cities; high proportion retirees and second-home owners
Key change driver	Gentrification (house prices rose from £165,000 (2005) to £530,000 (2023)), demographic change, regeneration of Electric Avenue market area	Counter-urbanisation, second home ownership (30%+ of properties), tourism growth, decline of fishing industry, coastal erosion risk
Community tensions	Displacement of Caribbean community by gentrification; cost of living crisis; crime; policing tensions	Housing unaffordability for local young people; conflict between tourism and residents; second homes reducing community vitality; lack of jobs for school-leavers
Lived experience — insider	"This has always been a vibrant, cultural community. Now we're being priced out by people who want the culture without the community." (long-term Brixton resident)	"Young people can't afford to stay here. We love Whitby but there are no jobs and we can't afford the houses that tourists and retirees buy." (local young person)
Lived experience — outsider	Media: "vibrant, multicultural, bohemian." Some: "crime, deprivation." Investors: "gentrification opportunity."	Tourists: "picturesque, historic, the Dracula connection, fish and chips." Investors: "holiday let opportunity."

Key comparison points: Both places face affordability challenges and community tension, but from opposite directions: Brixton from gentrification (prices rising too fast for residents), Whitby from holiday home ownership (second homes inflate prices, remove housing from permanent residents). Both have strong local identities threatened by external forces. Both have experienced significant economic change (Brixton: deindustrialisation then service sector boom; Whitby: fishing industry decline then tourism growth). The contrast in ethnic diversity is stark and reflects different migration histories.

6.8 Lived Experience and Perception vs Reality

Lived experience: The subjective, personal experience of individuals as they actually live in and move through a place, shaped by their identity (age, gender, ethnicity, class, sexuality, disability, religion), daily routines, relationships, and histories. Geographers such as Yi-Fu Tuan (topophilia — the love of place) and Doreen Massey argue that places have different meanings for different groups. A "place" is not a fixed, singular thing but a complex, multi-layered set of experiences.

How Identity Shapes Experience of Place

Identity Factor	How it shapes place experience	Example
Age	Young people may experience places as social spaces (nightlife, parks, meeting places); elderly may prioritise accessibility, safety, familiar landmarks; children's worlds are smaller (neighbourhood, school)	A young person in Whitby sees limited nightlife and job opportunities and feels excluded; a retiree sees beauty, tranquillity, and community
Gender	Women often modify behaviour due to safety concerns (avoiding certain routes at night, staying in lit areas). Public space is gendered: some spaces feel more welcoming to men or women.	A young woman walking in Bradford at night may feel unsafe in ways a man in the same space does not

Ethnicity/religion	Minority ethnic residents may experience familiar ethnic enclave areas as safe and welcoming while experiencing hostility or othering in predominantly white areas. Religious minorities may experience places through the lens of visible mosques, temples, churches.	A Bangladeshi resident of Brick Lane experiences it as culturally familiar (Banglatown); a White British visitor may experience it as "exotic"; a property developer sees a gentrification opportunity
Socioeconomic class	Wealthy residents access different parts of a city (private schools, exclusive neighbourhoods, restaurants) than poor residents (foodbanks, social housing estates, limited transport). The same city feels very different depending on income.	A Canary Wharf banker and a Poplar social housing resident live within walking distance but inhabit fundamentally different Londons
Length of residence	Long-term residents have deep attachments, memories of how places used to be, and often resist change. Recent arrivals are adapting, exploring, forming new connections. Transient populations (students, seasonal workers) have shallow place attachment.	A 70-year-old Brixton resident mourning the loss of Caribbean community contrasts with a 28-year-old professional who chose Brixton for its vibrancy

Perception vs Reality: Media and Place Stigma

Media representations of places can create perceptions that diverge significantly from measurable reality, with real consequences for investment, property values, and residents' wellbeing:

- **Crime and deprivation stigma:** Areas repeatedly portrayed as dangerous, violent, or deprived in news media suffer from reduced investment, lower property values, and damaged mental health among residents (who internalise negative portrayals). Research by Wacquant (2008) on "territorial stigmatisation" shows this is a global phenomenon affecting areas like Moss Side (Manchester), Hackney (London), Toxteth (Liverpool), and Bradford.
- **Jaywick, Essex:** media coverage of "Britain's most deprived place" creates stigma that residents actively resist. Many residents express pride and community spirit that outsider media portrayals miss entirely. The gap between statistics (deprivation index) and lived experience (community, heritage, belonging) is significant.

- **Rural idyll myth:** media representations of rural England (Cotswolds, Lake District, Yorkshire Dales) as peaceful, safe, wealthy, and overwhelmingly white mask real issues: rural poverty, isolation, mental health pressures (farmers' suicide rate), drug use, domestic abuse, lack of services. The "rural idyll" perception attracts wealthy incomers and drives up prices, exacerbating the problems it obscures.
- **TV and place promotion:** "Broadchurch" (filmed in West Bay, Dorset) increased tourism by 90%; "Happy Valley" (filmed in Calderdale, West Yorkshire) drove tourism to Halifax and Hebden Bridge despite depicting crime; "Game of Thrones" transformed tourism to Northern Ireland (screen tourism worth tens of millions of pounds a year).

Exam Tip: The concept of "lived experience" is central to Edexcel's Diverse Places topic. When answering questions about place, always consider WHOSE experience you are describing. A place can simultaneously be experienced as: a home with deep emotional attachment (long-term residents); an investment opportunity (property developers); a tourist attraction (visitors); a problem to be fixed (government agencies); a source of cultural pride (ethnic communities). Demonstrating this multiplicity of experience earns AO2 marks. Reference theorists Yi-Fu Tuan (topophilia), Doreen Massey (power geometry — different groups have different relationships to mobility and place), and Wacquant (territorial stigmatisation) where appropriate.

6.9 UK Census Data and Measuring Place Characteristics

What the Census Tells Us

The UK Census (conducted every 10 years; most recent 2021) provides the most comprehensive snapshot of place characteristics. Key variables and what they reveal:

Census Variable	What it reveals about place	Example data (2021)
Population size and density	Urban/rural character, pressure on land and services	London: 5,701 per km ² ; North Yorkshire: 75 per km ²
Country of birth	Migration history, international connections	London: ~41% born outside UK; Wales: ~7% born outside UK
Ethnic group	Diversity, community composition, potential for	Leicester: <50% White British (majority minority city); Boston, Lincs: one of England's highest shares of

	cultural richness or tension	residents born in Eastern Europe
Religion	Cultural and community character	Bradford: 30.5% Muslim; England and Wales average: 6.5% Muslim; Bradford 28% no religion vs 37% nationally
Economic activity	Employment patterns, deprivation, skills base	Jaywick: 62% economically inactive; City of London: 82% employment rate
NS-SEC (occupational class)	Social class composition; professional vs working class character	Guildford: 44% in highest managerial/professional class; Burnley: 16%
Housing tenure	Owner-occupation vs renting; private vs social rented; stability of population	Kensington: 45% private rented; Sunderland: 62% owner-occupied; Tower Hamlets: 42% social rent
Qualifications	Human capital; education levels affecting economic prospects	Cambridge: 47% degree-level or above; Jaywick: 50% no qualifications
Health — self-reported	Wellbeing; links to deprivation, environment, age structure	Blackpool: 12% report "bad" or "very bad" health; Richmond (Surrey): 3%

Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD)

Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD): England's official measure of relative deprivation across seven domains: income, employment, education/skills/training, health/disability, crime, barriers to housing/services, and living environment. Calculated at Lower Super Output Area (LSOA) level (~1,500 residents each), producing a ranking of every LSOA (33,755 in the 2025 edition). Updated every 4–6 years (most recently 2025). It measures relative deprivation (how areas rank against each other) not absolute poverty.

Key IMD findings (2019):

- **Most deprived:** Blackpool is the most deprived local authority in England (top 10% most deprived LSOAs in almost all domains). Other highly deprived areas: Knowsley (Merseyside), Liverpool, Kingston upon Hull, Middlesbrough, Hastings.
- **Least deprived:** Hart (Hampshire), Rushcliffe (Nottinghamshire), Elmbridge (Surrey), St Albans (Hertfordshire).
- **Coastal deprivation:** Jaywick (Essex), Clacton, Skegness, and Margate are examples of severely deprived coastal communities — a distinct form of deprivation linked to isolation, declining tourism, low land values, and limited employment.
- **North-South divide:** 8 of the 10 most deprived local authorities are in the North of England or Midlands. The North-South divide in deprivation is persistent and has widened since 2010.
- **London paradox:** London contains both very high deprivation (Tower Hamlets, Hackney, Newham) and the least deprived areas nationally (parts of Kensington, Richmond, Westminster). The range within London is greater than between most other regions.

6.10 Field Study Methodologies for Diverse Places

Edexcel requires students to undertake fieldwork in both studied places, using quantitative and qualitative methods. Understanding and being able to evaluate these methods is important for the exam.

Quantitative Methods

Method	What it measures	Strengths	Limitations
Environmental quality surveys (EQS)	Rate visible aspects of the environment (housing condition, litter, graffiti, greenery, noise, traffic) on a numerical scale (e.g. 1–5)	Generates comparable numerical data across different streets/areas; can be repeated and compared over time; objective-seeming; easy to map	Subjective despite numerical scale (different surveyors may rate same feature differently); only captures visible environment; snapshot in time; doesn't capture lived experience or safety perceptions

Pedestrian counts	Number of pedestrians in a given area over a time period	Indicates vitality/footfall; compares areas; can be stratified by time of day; low-cost	Varies enormously by time, weather, day of week; doesn't reveal why people are there or their experience
Land use surveys	Mapping retail/commercial types (A1 shops, A3 food, financial services, vacant units) along a high street	Reveals economic character of place; vacancy rates indicate decline; change over time reveals trends; easily mapped using OS base	Snapshot; misses uses inside buildings; ignores online/remote businesses; subjective land use classification choices
Secondary data analysis	Census data, IMD scores, house prices (Land Registry), crime statistics (police.uk), school performance (Ofsted), life expectancy (ONS)	Comprehensive, collected by professionals, comparable across areas, longitudinal (time series), authoritative	Not specific to small sub-areas; census is only every 10 years (becomes dated); categories may not reflect lived reality; proxy measures (IMD) may miss important dimensions of deprivation or wellbeing

Qualitative Methods

Method	What it reveals	Strengths	Limitations
Structured interviews / questionnaires	Residents' opinions, perceptions, lived experience, satisfaction with services and environment	Captures subjective experience; can include demographic information to compare across groups (age, ethnicity, tenure); can be replicated for comparison	Sampling bias (who is willing to talk); social desirability bias (people say what they think you want to hear); interviewer effect; time-consuming; limited sample size

Semi-structured or unstructured interviews	In-depth perspectives; allows respondents to raise issues the researcher hadn't anticipated; rich qualitative data	Captures nuance and complexity; empowers respondents to share their own narratives; discovers unexpected insights	Not comparable across interviews; researcher interpretation introduces subjectivity; very time-consuming; small sample limits generalisability
Photo/video documentation	Visual evidence of environmental character, change over time (historical photos), community life	Powerful evidence; captures aspects hard to describe numerically; accessible	Photos are selective and can misrepresent; photographer's perspective influences what is captured; ethical issues (photographing people requires consent)
Mental mapping	How people perceive the spatial structure of their place: which areas feel safe/unsafe, important/unimportant, familiar/unfamiliar	Reveals subjective geographies; highlights differences between groups (e.g. elderly vs young people's cognitive maps); can identify perceived "no-go" areas	Difficult to compare systematically; small samples; people may not be able to accurately represent their perceptions cartographically
Observation / ethnography	How people actually use and interact in space; who is present/absent at different times; atmosphere and character	Captures reality rather than reported behaviour; notes details that surveys would miss; rich contextual data	Observer effect (presence changes behaviour); time-consuming; researcher subjectivity; ethical issues in public space research

Exam Tip: In the exam you may be asked to "assess the suitability of a method for investigating lived experience of place." Always evaluate: what does this method capture well? What does it miss? What are the potential sources of bias or error? What sample size is realistic? A sophisticated answer will note that combining quantitative methods (which capture patterns and allow comparison) with

qualitative methods (which capture meaning and lived experience) gives a fuller picture than either alone — this is called "methodological triangulation."

6.11 Place Change: Worked Exam Questions

Question 1 (4 marks): Explain the difference between insider and outsider perspectives on place.

Model Answer:

An insider perspective is the view of a place held by those who live or belong there, shaped by direct lived experience, personal memories, daily routines, and emotional attachment. Insiders have deep, nuanced knowledge of their place but may be so accustomed to it that they do not notice gradual change. They often have a strong emotional stake in how the place is represented. For example, a long-term Brixton resident may experience the area as a vibrant Caribbean community centre, even as statistics show rapid gentrification.

An outsider perspective is that of visitors, media, government agencies, or developers who view a place without this lived knowledge. Outsiders may rely on statistics, stereotypes, or limited visits, and their views are often shaped by dominant media narratives. They may perceive Brixton primarily as a "cool," gentrifying neighbourhood (property developers) or as a deprived, crime-affected area (media). Neither outsider view captures the full complexity that insiders experience. Importantly, multiple insider perspectives also exist: a young Bangladeshi woman's sense of Tower Hamlets differs from that of a male Bangladeshi elder or a long-term White British resident.

Question 2 (8 marks): Assess the extent to which regeneration has been successful in an urban place you have studied.

Model Answer Framework (using Canary Wharf / London Docklands):

Define the strategy: The London Docklands Development Corporation (LDDC) led property-led regeneration of East London's derelict docklands from 1981, creating Canary Wharf as a major financial district.

Evidence of success: 120,000 high-skilled jobs; £10 billion annual business rates; world-class infrastructure (DLR, Jubilee Line, Elizabeth Line); transformed physical environment; international

profile as a global financial centre; population growth (39,000 to 110,000 on Isle of Dogs).

Evidence of limitations: Average house price £690,000 (largely inaccessible to original community); child poverty rate 56% in nearby Poplar wards; Tower Hamlets remains one of the most deprived London boroughs; only 1,900 affordable homes built by LDDC in 17 years; original dockworkers' community largely displaced; the financial sector is volatile (2008 financial crisis threatened Canary Wharf significantly); benefits largely accrued to incomers and shareholders rather than existing residents; top-down model bypassed local democratic accountability.

Balanced conclusion: Canary Wharf is a spectacular success by economic metrics but a very partial success by social metrics. It transformed the physical and economic landscape but failed to address deprivation among communities that most needed regeneration. "Success" depends entirely on what criteria you use and whose interests you prioritise — a fundamental tension in all regeneration policy.

Question 3 (12 marks): "The lived experience of a place is more important than quantitative data in understanding diverse places." To what extent do you agree?

Model Answer Framework:

For (qualitative/lived experience): Lived experience captures subjective meaning, emotional attachment, and the human dimensions of place that no statistic can convey. IMD data may rank Jaywick as England's most deprived, but residents describe strong community bonds, coastal beauty, and a sense of belonging that the deprivation index entirely misses. Doreen Massey argues that place is fundamentally about social relationships and power — things felt and lived, not just measured. Mental mapping reveals how differently the same space is experienced: a young Pakistani woman's Bradford differs profoundly from a White British man's. Qualitative fieldwork through interviews and observation captures these nuances. Understanding why people feel pride, anxiety, belonging, or exclusion requires listening to voices, not reading spreadsheets.

Against (case for quantitative data): However, quantitative data has irreplaceable value. Census figures, IMD scores, house price data, crime statistics, and employment rates enable systematic comparison between places, tracking of change over time, and identification of patterns at scale. Without these, we cannot determine whether Jaywick is more or less deprived than Blackpool, whether gentrification is accelerating, or whether a regeneration intervention has reduced unemployment. Policy decisions require comparable, reliable data. Qualitative evidence from small

samples may not be representative. A single insider's positive experience of a place does not disprove systematic deprivation data.

Synthesis and judgement: The most powerful geographical understanding of diverse places combines both approaches. Quantitative data provides the structural context (what is objectively measurable about the place); lived experience provides the human geography (what it means to live there). Neither alone is sufficient. The Edexcel approach requires students to use both types of evidence — primary fieldwork (often qualitative) and secondary data (quantitative) — and this duality reflects a genuine epistemological position: places have both objective characteristics and subjective meanings, and geography must engage with both.

6.12 Key Data Points for Exam Use

Place / Indicator	Key Data
Tower Hamlets demographics (2021)	320,000 population; 35% Bangladeshi heritage; 41% born outside UK; 270+ nationalities in London borough
Canary Wharf employment	120,000 workers; average salary £100,000+; 37 million sq ft commercial space
Canary Wharf housing	Average house price £690,000; 42% social rent in Tower Hamlets; LDDC built only 1,900 affordable homes
Jaywick deprivation	Most deprived LSOA in England (every IMD since 2010, including 2025); 62% economically inactive; median household income £14,000; life expectancy 8 years below average
Bradford ethnicity	~26% Pakistani heritage; ~30% Muslim; ~39% ethnic minority (2021 Census); among England's most deprived LAs
UK manufacturing employment	7.9 million (1971) → 2.7 million (2020) — deindustrialisation
UK online retail	27% of total retail sales (2023); high street vacancy rate ~14%

Leicester diversity	One of the UK's first "majority minority" cities (2021 Census: ~33% White British, ~59% from ethnic minority groups)
Boston, Lincolnshire	Rapid Eastern European migration after 2004; voted 75.6% Leave in 2016 Brexit referendum
Brixton house prices	£165,000 (2005) → £530,000 (2023) — gentrification
Cotswolds house prices	Average £425,000 vs national £290,000; 6 million visitors/yr
Hull City of Culture 2017	£300 million economic impact; 5.3 million visits; culture-led regeneration
Life expectancy inequality	~10-year gap in life expectancy and nearly 20-year gap in healthy life expectancy between most and least deprived areas in England
Bradford 2001 riots	326 police injured; £10 million property damage; Cattle Report on "parallel lives"

6.13 Theoretical Perspectives on Place

Yi-Fu Tuan — Topophilia

Yi-Fu Tuan (1974) introduced the concept of **topophilia** — "the affective bond between people and place or setting." Tuan argued that places acquire meaning through human experience, memory, and emotion. A childhood home, a school playground, or a grandmother's street become imbued with personal significance that outsiders cannot perceive from observation or statistics alone. Tuan distinguished between "place" (meaningful, experiential) and "space" (abstract, geometric). A space becomes a place when people dwell in it, use it, and attach meaning to it.

Application: Topophilia helps explain why communities resist regeneration and change even when their area is objectively deprived. Long-term residents of estates marked for demolition often express deep attachment to buildings that outsiders see only as dilapidated housing. The emotional geographies of place are real and powerful, regardless of what statistics say.

Doreen Massey — A Global Sense of Place and Power Geometry

Doreen Massey (1994) challenged parochial, nostalgic conceptions of place. She argued that places are not bounded, fixed, or static; they are defined by their connections to other places. Massey's "global sense of place" recognises that Brixton, Bradford, or Whitby are all constituted through global flows of people, goods, ideas, and capital. A Pakistani restaurant in Bradford connects that place to Lahore, Karachi, and the global food economy. The Canary Wharf development connects the Isle of Dogs to Hong Kong, New York, and global financial markets.

Massey's concept of **power geometry** recognises that different groups have fundamentally different relationships to mobility and global connections. A Canary Wharf banker can work globally, fly anywhere, and move between cities easily. A low-wage worker in the same borough may have a very restricted mobility, dependent on local bus routes, unable to access the global economy that literally surrounds them. This power geometry shapes who benefits from globalisation and place change, and who bears its costs.

Wacquant — Territorial Stigmatisation

Loïc Wacquant (2008) coined the term **territorial stigmatisation** to describe how certain urban areas become associated in public discourse with poverty, crime, moral decay, and danger. This stigmatisation — perpetuated by media representations, political rhetoric, and official statistics — has real material consequences:

- Businesses are deterred from investing in stigmatised areas.
- Property values are suppressed, concentrating poverty further.
- Residents suffer psychological harm and internalise negative self-images.
- Young people from stigmatised postcodes face discrimination in the job market.
- Residents develop strategies to "escape" the stigma of their address (not telling employers their postcode, taking buses to interviews from adjacent, less-stigmatised areas).

Jaywick, Moss Side, Toxteth, and Blackpool all exemplify territorial stigmatisation. In the exam, citing Wacquant demonstrates that you understand place representations have power — they are not neutral descriptions but active forces shaping the prospects of real communities.

6.14 Social and Economic Inequality Between Places

The North-South Divide in England

The North-South divide refers to the persistent economic gap between England's northern regions (North East, North West, Yorkshire & Humber) and the south (London, South East, East of England). Key indicators:

Indicator	London / South East	North East England
GVA per head (2022)	London: £58,000; South East: £33,000	North East: £21,000 (lowest in England)
Unemployment rate	London: ~4%; South East: ~3%	North East: ~6% (historically highest)
Life expectancy at birth (male)	London: 81 years; Surrey: 82 years	Hartlepool: 74.7 years; Middlesbrough: 74.5 years
Average house price (2023)	London: £512,000; Surrey: £495,000	County Durham: £155,000; Sunderland: £140,000
% with degree-level qualifications	London: 57%; South East: 45%	North East: 34%

The divide has deep historical roots: northern England's industrial revolution created wealth through coal, steel, shipbuilding, and textiles, but deindustrialisation from the 1970s destroyed these economies without adequate replacement. London's growth as a global financial and service centre absorbed talent and investment from across the UK, widening the divide.

Government responses: The "Levelling Up" agenda (2022 White Paper; the label was dropped by the Labour government elected in 2024, though devolution continued) acknowledged the divide and pledged investment in northern cities (Northern Powerhouse Rail, Freeports, investment zones, devolution deals with Greater Manchester, West Yorkshire, and Tees Valley). However, critics argue levelling up funding has been modest relative to the scale of the problem, and political instability has disrupted delivery. The Tees Valley Combined Authority (led by Ben Houchen, Conservative Mayor) has attracted Freeport status and investment in the hydrogen economy around the former Redcar steelworks site.

Rural-Urban Inequality

Rural deprivation is a hidden problem: rural areas score better than urban areas on many IMD measures (crime is lower, environment better, housing less overcrowded), masking pockets of severe rural poverty. Rural deprivation has distinctive features:

- **Dispersal:** rural poor are geographically dispersed and less visible than urban poor concentrated in estates.
- **Transport poverty:** limited or no public transport means not owning a car is severely disabling. Rural bus services cut by 50%+ since 2008 (Campaign for Better Transport). GPs, hospitals, supermarkets, and job centres may be 15+ miles away.
- **Service withdrawal:** village shops, pubs, post offices, schools, and GP surgeries closing as populations thin out and the economics become marginal. England lost 10,500 pubs between 2005 and 2020.
- **Housing unaffordability:** in-migration of wealthier counter-urbanisers and second-home owners inflates house prices in desirable rural areas beyond the reach of local young people on rural wages (which tend to be lower than urban wages). In some Cotswolds villages, 30-40% of properties are second homes.
- **Digital exclusion:** broadband connectivity in rural areas has improved but remains slower and more expensive than urban areas; 4G/5G coverage patchy. This disadvantages rural businesses and remote workers.

Exam Tip: When comparing your two studied places, always use the four main categories of characteristic: demographic (population composition, migration, age structure), economic (employment, income, deprivation), social (health, education, crime, housing), and cultural (ethnicity, religion, language, heritage). For each category, use specific named data (census 2021 figures, IMD 2019 rank, house prices from Land Registry, life expectancy from ONS). The most sophisticated comparative responses will also use theoretical concepts: Massey's power geometry to explain why some residents benefit more than others from place change; Wacquant's territorial stigmatisation to analyse media representations; Tuan's topophilia to explain community resistance to regeneration.

6.15 Planning, Policy, and Place Futures

National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF)

The NPPF (England) sets out the government's planning policies. A key tension it embodies is between:

- **Development pressures:** housing shortage (the government's target is 1.5 million new homes in England in 2024–29, ~300,000/yr; ~170,000–250,000 have been built a year recently); economic growth requirements; infrastructure needs.

- **Conservation objectives:** protecting Green Belt (1.6 million hectares around major cities); preserving Areas of Outstanding Natural Beauty (AONBs); protecting heritage assets; limiting urban sprawl.

The December 2024 NPPF introduced "grey belt" (lower-quality Green Belt) development to help meet housing targets, sparking significant political controversy. This illustrates how national policy shapes local place character — communities that resist development face housing crises; those that accept it face landscape and community change.

Neighbourhood Planning

Since the Localism Act (2011), communities can produce Neighbourhood Plans — local planning documents that shape development in their area, provided they are consistent with the Local Plan. Over 2,500 neighbourhood plans have been "made" (adopted) in England. Most are produced by relatively affluent, well-organised communities in rural and suburban areas — ironically, areas least in need of planning protection. Deprived urban communities, with fewer resources and less planning knowledge, are less likely to produce neighbourhood plans. This means bottom-up planning has benefits but also risks reinforcing existing privilege.